

HM414 (Open Elective, Winter 2025-26)
A Beginner's Introduction to the Psyche
Instructor: Dr. Jenson Joseph

Course format: 3 hours of lectures (3-0-0-3)

Pre-requisites: HSS core courses

Course outline:

There are two primary approaches to the entity at the centre of this course – the psyche. One understands it as the site that constitutes human subjectivity, imbuing our experience of life and the world with meaning and value. The other views it as the site of pathological issues. These approaches have generated two distinct intellectual discourses on the workings of the psyche: psychoanalysis and psychology. While the latter is largely a clinical practice focused on helping people cope with the pathologies of the mind, psychoanalysis has evolved as a powerful explanatory and interpretative framework, offering a theory of the psyche as a generative domain through which virtually all aspects of life – and the social, cultural, and political formations arising from it – can be understood. This course introduces foundational concepts from these disciplines through a discussion of the seminal theories proposed by Sigmund Freud (1856-1939) and Jacques Lacan (1901-1981).

We will explore Freud's theories of the unconscious, the pleasure principle, the Oedipus complex, and the triadic structure of the id, ego, and superego. We will also examine Lacan's concepts of the Mirror Stage, alienation, and his schema of the Symbolic, Imaginary, and the Real. Cultural and media texts, literary works, and discussions of current events will be used to introduce these complex concepts and help students develop a basic understanding of the human psyche, its operations, and why it matters to study them. The course will also delve into methods of applying the psychoanalytic framework to evolve understandings and interpretations of socio-political and cultural phenomena, especially when they involve matters of the spirit. These discussions will build toward a thematic focus on socio-cultural transformations in the age of algorithms and artificial intelligence, examined from the vantage point of their impact on the psyche and on the constitution of the modern subject, in contrast to the era of industrial capitalism in which classical psychoanalytic theories were devised.

Course Outcome: At the basic level, this course is meant to encourage students to develop an interest in key concepts in the discourses on the human psyche by exploring immediately relatable questions such as: Why do human beings experience adult life as a landscape of complex emotions and inner conflicts that defy rational explanation? Why

do we struggle to control, express, or even recognize our desires? What is the origin of our dreams? What makes us dependent on others or objects, sometimes to our own detriment? Why is “madness” a uniquely human condition seemingly tied to our capacity for reason? Why do we often feel we lack full control over our will and consciousness, as though an alien force resides within us?

By helping students develop perspectives that enable them to engage such questions, the course equips them to understand the human psyche as a powerful faculty whose operations produce both meaning and value as well as potential pathologies. In an age when self-care and self-management are fetishized as pathways to well-being, this course encourages students to reflect on the self, society, and the structures that shape psychic formations. For participants who show particular interest, the course will also introduce procedures for interpreting socio-cultural phenomena from a psychoanalytic perspective.

Course material:

Berg, H. de. (2004). *Freud's theory and its uses in literary and cultural studies: An introduction*. Camden House.

Lear, J. (2008). *Freud*. Routledge.

Phillips, A. (Ed.). (2006). *The Sigmund Freud reader*. Penguin Books.

Roudinesco, É. (2014). *Lacan: In spite of everything*. Verso Books.

Žižek, S. (2001). *Enjoy your symptom! Jacques Lacan in Hollywood and out*. Routledge.

Journal Articles

Mulvey, L. (1975). 'Visual pleasure and narrative cinema'. *Screen*, 16(3), 6–18.

Literary Works and Films

Borges, J. L. (1941). *The lottery in Babylon*.

Kafka, F. (1915). *The metamorphosis*.

Bergman, I. (Director). (1966). *Persona* [Film]. Svensk Filmindustri.

Bhardwaj, V. (Director). (2003). *Maqbool* [Film]. Kaleidoscope Entertainment/Bobby Bedi.

Hitchcock, A. (Director). (1958). *Vertigo* [Film]. AH Productions/Paramount Pictures.

Jonze, S. (Director). (2013). *Her* [Film]. Warner Bros.

Lee, A. (Director). (2005). *Brokeback mountain* [Film]. Focus Features.

Santhoshi, R. (Director). (1993). *Damini* [Film]. Cineyug Entertainment.

Selected texts from Indian literature to be added.

Class presentations: Students will be assigned literary and media texts which they will analyse using the concepts discussed in class.

Grading Policy (subject to change as the course progresses)

Class presentations (2): 40%

In-Sem Exam II: 30%

Project: 30%